

CEHD Research Conversation:

Lived Experience Studies in Applied Research and Evaluation

Qualitative and community-based approaches

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PROMOTING THE INCLUSION OF PEOPLE WITH DISABILITIES



Boston Children's Hospital

Where the world comes for answers

What brings me to this work?

- Clinical social work
- Sociocultural anthropology
- Lived experience
- Disability justice



Qualitative Lived Experience Studies in Applied Research and Evaluation

- People with lived experience are experts:
 - Program, service, or benefit recipients (or potential participants) People impacted by policies or systems
 - Members of marginalized or underrepresented groups
- In-depth interviews and focus groups
 - Series of interviews for longitudinal perspective if possible
- Open-ended questions, such as:
 - Goals, Needs, Barriers, Success
 - Services received or gaps in services
 - Circumstances and stories that are important to participants
- One dimension among others:
 - Outcome research/evaluation (incl. experimental or quasi-experimental designs)
 - Process evaluation, staff perspectives
 - Satisfaction surveys

Why Qualitative Methods?

Why are qualitative lived experience studies important in applied research?

- Adds depth and context
- Discovers dimensions not considered
- Explains quantitative results, including exceptions
- Highlights the voices of those most impacted

Current/Recent Areas of Study

Disability services and systems:

- Employment for adults and transition-age youth
- Vocational Rehabilitation
- Centers for Independent Living

Native Communities:

- Perspectives on wealth among Native Americans
- Employment experiences of Native people impacted by opioid addiction



Vocational Rehabilitation (VR)

- State VR agencies:
 - provide employment services to people with disabilities
 - help people choose, prepare for, get, and keep jobs
 - competitive integrated employment is the goal
- ICI does research and evaluation with VR agencies, studying innovations in service delivery.



Lived Experience Studies for Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) Model Demonstrations

Goals:

- Provide ongoing feedback
- Explain or add depth to quantitative data
- Add to knowledge about VR and employment for people with disabilities

Methods/Population:

- In-depth interviews w/VR consumers
- Rolling/repeated outreach and follow-up interviews

Outputs:

- Reports and presentations to VR agency leaders and staff
- Peer-reviewed journal articles
- Conference presentations
- Future projects



VR Model Demonstration Example: SGA Project

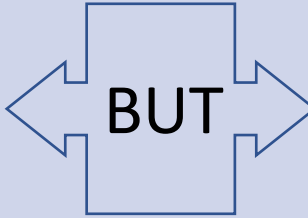
- Randomized Controlled Trial
- Tested a VR service innovation for social security disability insurance (SSDI) beneficiaries
- Lived experience study: 107 interviews with 48 VR customers



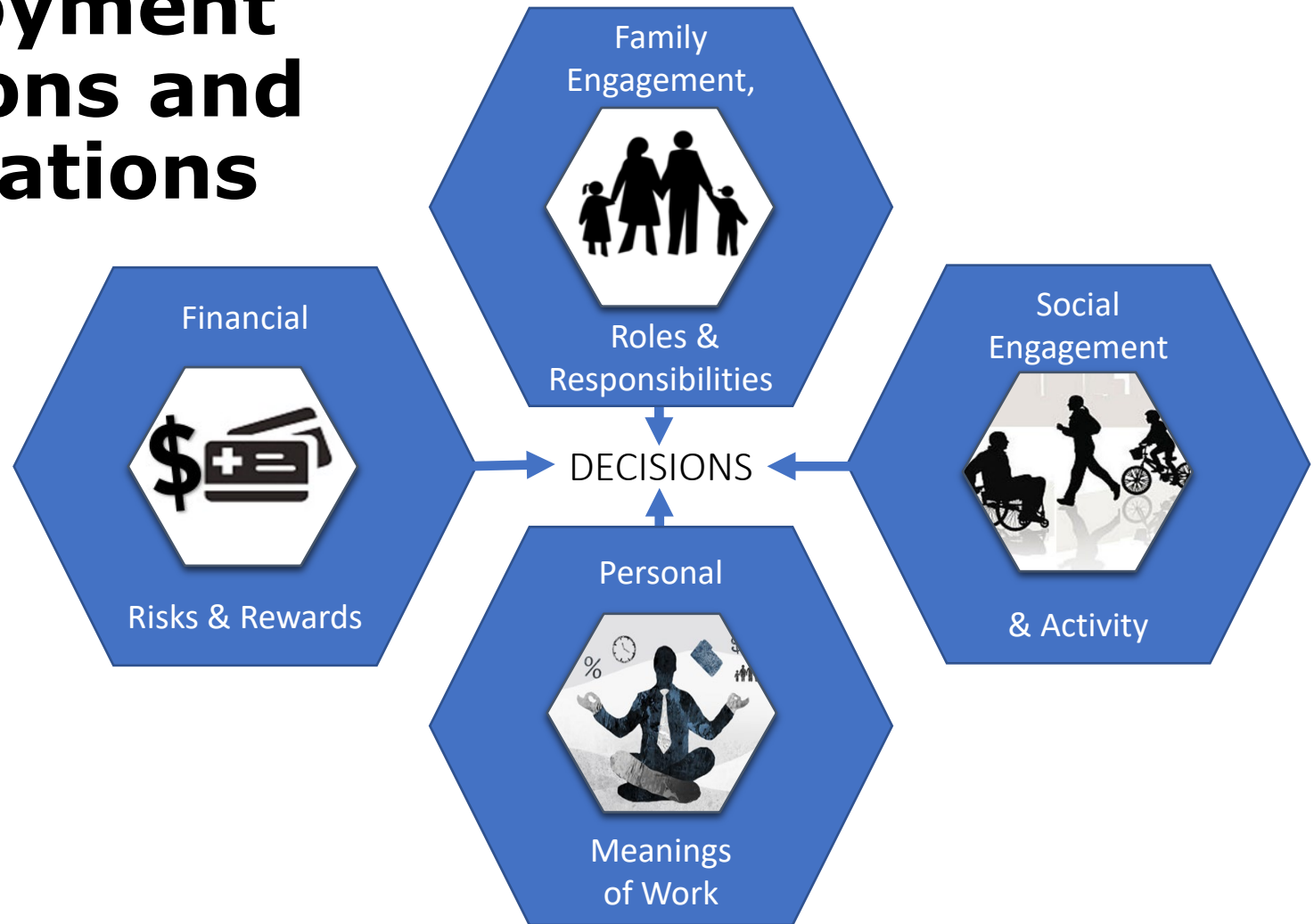
SSDI Beneficiaries and Returning to Work

All participants were SSDI beneficiaries and seeking employment services from VR.

Why is this important?

Significant work histories		Low employment rates
May work some		Not working full-time
If earn above set \$ (SGA), SSDI payments end		Want to earn enough to support themselves/families

Findings: Employment Decisions and Motivations



Family Roles and Responsibilities

I'm trying to be as self-sufficient as I can because I have children, and I want to be a good example. ... I just try to work as much as I can so we can be able to make it and be able to handle it, because just on this Social Security, on my own now, I'm struggling. It's hard.



Personal Meanings of Work

[Q: And what do you think it would be like to work and go off disability?]

Well, for one, my self-esteem would be built because I know that I would be doing something to help other people and that I belong somewhere, that I'm needed somewhere. And the feeling to be needed, that goes a long, long way...

I want to feel like I belong. I want to feel like I'm part of the society. And when you're on disability, you're this little group over here outside the circle with the rest of the world.



Financial Risks and Rewards

Having a full-time job and benefits is very tempting. And I would really like to have that kind of security again. [But] you know, the SSDI, I don't know how much it would affect it. And then I don't know if I'd make enough to have a living wage.



VR Services: Financial/Benefits Counseling

When I first started thinking about getting back to work,...[there was] the fear of losing the little I was getting.

I didn't know if...I could do a full day of work.... Everything was just so uncertain. It would have been really nice to have a little bit of certainty in ... understanding what happens with SSI and SSDI and Medicare or Medicaid when you start working.



Pacing: VR Services Too Slow

I wasn't prepared for how slow the pace was.

I was facing a big shortfall like within four weeks. So I needed a job now. I needed to start working.



Job Placement: Need more help finding jobs

I thought that it would be a placement, not a search. You know what I'm saying?

...The relationships should already be there with the employers to place people based on their ability and capabilities to work and what they can do. I think those jobs should already be available for me.



Model Responsive to Customers

What VR Customers said

- Pace:
 - Ready to work
 - VR process is too slow
- Complex Decisions
 - Needs/goals v. risks
- SSDI:
 - Rules are confusing
 - Fear losing benefits
- Job Placement:
 - Want targeted help to find jobs

Rapid Engagement Team Approach (RETA)



Rapid Engagement

Coordinated Team Approach



Early Financial and Benefits Planning

Early Job Search Planning



Rapid Engagement Team Approach (RETA) (2025-2028)

Goals:

- Help VR agencies use RETA to:
 - Improve engagement in services
 - Improve employment outcomes
 - Increase wages
- Economic independence and wellbeing for people with disabilities

Activities:

- Create a toolkit
- Engage VR agencies to implement RETA
- Host a learning collaborative for VR agencies
- **Gather perspectives of VR participants to embed lived experience into RETA**



Other Projects with Lived Experience Studies

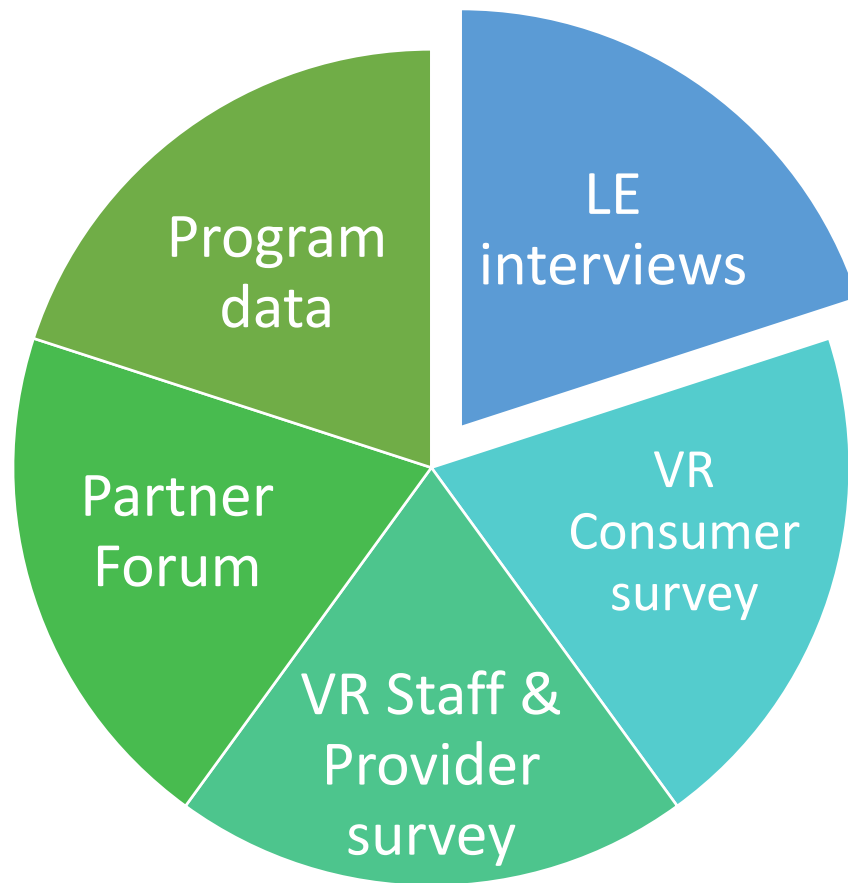
A few recent examples:

- Comprehensive State Needs Assessments Trauma-informed Approaches in Centers for Independent Living
- Native American Perspectives on Wealth
- Native Equity in Employment and Recovery (ongoing)



Comprehensive State Needs Assessment

- Contract with state VR agency
- Goal is to help VR Agency understand:
 - Needs of people with disabilities in the state
 - System capacity to meet those needs
 - Recommendations to support employment and independence of PWD
- Methods for LE study:
 - Interviews w/adults with disabilities
- Outputs:
 - Public report
 - Presentation to VR agency and State Rehabilitation Council

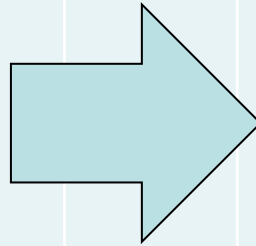




In-depth interviews of New Hampshire residents with disabilities

Awareness

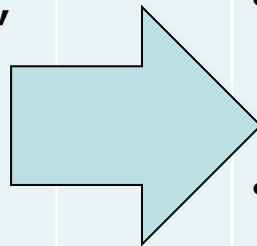
- Mostly **unaware** of VR
- **Interested** in services
- **Confused** about how or when to apply



- **Outreach:** healthcare providers, accessible website, community organizations
- Share info: **what, how, when**

Access

- **Overwhelmed** by systems, competing demands on time/energy
- **Transportation** was a major barrier



- Help **parents**, people w/**acquired disabilities** to navigate systems
- Expand info & support for **transportation**



In-depth interviews of New Hampshire residents with disabilities

"Trying to navigate the system of disability is a full-time job and one that I had to learn very fast."

"As someone who's entirely new to the world of disability... everything feels overwhelming."

Individual w/
Long COVID



"To be a mom with so many things going on and remembering to email teachers and coordinate, the burnout and the brain fog just make me too tired to really have any more energy and just brain capacity to do things."

Parent with a
disability



"Right now I'm not in the stage of going back to work yet. So I guess I don't know if it's the right time."

"I wonder if the best connection is...with medical teams...I'm accessing a lot of the...return to work planning through my occupational therapist."

Individuals with
acquired
disabilities



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Challenges



Logistics: outreach and recruitment



Limitations: working within the constraints of the funder and partners



Resources: qualitative data analysis is complex and takes time



Choosing what to report and how: comprehensive v. succinct, useful v. interesting/compelling

Why do people participate in lived experience research?

Human connection:

- *It's so good to have somebody to vent, you know, it's nice...in this lonely world.*

Voice being valued:

- *As soon as I saw [the announcement], I was like, wow, that's going to be interesting. Nobody's ever asked me before.*

Improving systems and helping people:

- *I'm glad that you guys are there for making sure that all the I's are dotted and the T's are crossed, you know? Because without you guys, then somebody would not be doing what they're doing, you know?*
- *Well, thank you guys for doing this. Because it's also going to help people like me, so I'm really happy to be a part of it.*



Questions?

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